**Movie Maverick: 100 Years of Roger Corman**

# The Wild Angels

**The Wild Angels**
*Director*: Roger Corman
*Production Company*:
American International Productions
*Producer*: Roger Corman
*Associate Producer*: Laurence Cruikshank
*Production Manager*: Jack Bohrer
*Assistant Director*: Paul Rapp
*Assistant to Director*: Peter Bogdanovich
*Screenplay*: Charles B. Griffith
*Photography*: Richard Moore
*Editor*: Monte Hellman
*Production Designer*: Richard Beck-Meyer
*Art Director*: Leon Ericksen
*Wardrobe*: Glenn Wright
*Make-up*: Jack Obringer
*Hairstyling*: Susan Germaine
*Music*: Mike Curb
*Sound*: Phil Mitchell
*Cast:*
Peter Fonda *(Heavenly Blues)*
Nancy Sinatra *(Mike)*
Bruce Dern *(Loser)*
Lou Procopio *(Joint)*
Coby Denton *(Bull Puckey)*
Norman Alden *(Medic)*
Buck Taylor *(Dear John)*
Michael J. Pollard *(Pigmy)*
Diane Ladd *(Gaysh)*
Joan Shawlee *(Mama Monahan)*
Gayle Hunnicutt *(Suzie)*
Art Baker *(Thomas)*
Frank Maxwell *(Preacher)*
Frank Gerstle *(hospital policeman)*
Kim Hamilton *(nurse)*
Marc Cavell *(Frankenstein)*
Dick Miller *(construction workman)*
Barboura Morris *(worried mother)*
Peter Bogdanovich *(on-looker at funeral)*
Venice Hell's Angels, California
USA 1966
86 mins
Digital (restoration)

Restored by Roundabout, working from a 4K scan of the 35mm original camera negative.

The screening on Thu 12 Nov will be introduced by Catherine Corman, Roger Corman's daughter


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SIGHT AND SOUND


**SPOILER WARNING** The following notes give away some of the plot.

## A contemporary review

It's now ten years since Dick Miller accidentally stuck a knife through the cat in his bedroom wall and converted the result into an indignant statuette. That was in Roger Corman's *A Bucket of Blood*, a taut, modest and uneven curio built around the theme of a misfit whose enemies all get encased in plaster to further the cause of art. It seems a comparatively low rung on the ladder Corman has since briskly ascended to his present big-budget elevation, but it is a significant one. For within a few months of completing *A Bucket of Blood* Corman was preparing *House of Usher*, and cats in walls, uncontrolled eccentrics, and corpses on permanent display dominated the films he made – around 20 of them – during the next five years.

That these are traditional horror elements has of necessity made Corman himself a difficult director to sum up; it hasn't really been possible to decide what was genuine Corman and what was rearranged Edgar Allan Poe, although the rearrangement provided plenty of clues. And while the profitable cycle was being worked out this hasn't mattered too much – there has been more than enough to celebrate in Corman's technique alone as it ascended, film by film, to the elaborate ritual of *Masque of the Red Death*. When he came up with the sharp and confusing contrasts of a war film, a study of motorcycle hoodlums, a reconstruction of the Al Capone period and a piece on drug-taking, it seemed that technique was indeed the sole interest of Corman the filmmaker, and that having extracted every possible variation from Vincent Price's by no means unlimited range he was moving on to other proved methods of meeting box-office demands.

As it turns out, the censorship delays that have kept Britain from seeing *The Wild Angels* and *The Trip* until the 1968 Edinburgh Festival have deprived us to a startling extent of the opportunity of getting Corman into perspective. For instead of being the expected break with the wistful dream-world of Ligeia they both refer back repeatedly to the preoccupations of the Poe films, serving with an irrefutable clarity to expand, to augment, and to integrate these into the contemporary setting where fundamentally, of course, they have belonged all along. The cats seem to have taken their leave (discounting those on motorcycles), but the eccentrics and the walking dead are so prominent that to ignore them would be like trying to deny Bergman his greasepaint, Buñuel his clerics, and Resnais his memory.

On the other hand, the exciting thing about both films, which themselves link together in a number of ways almost as an independent unit, is that far from being retrospective and derivative they lead the technical as well as the thematic Corman forward – many of their sequences embody the best work he has done. In abandoning, only temporarily one hopes, Daniel Haller's splendid array of cobwebbed dungeons, Corman has discovered the intoxicating delights of location photography, not just in the sense of colour and landscape but also in terms of people. The greatest difference between *A Bucket of Blood* and *The Wild Angels*, both written by Charles B. Griffith, is that while in the former the cast declaims somewhat self-consciously in overcrowded and oppressive studio sets, the latter puts its characters out on the open road and contemplates them expansively from enormous distances – with the result that their movements are more relaxed, their words more spontaneous.

Not that *Wild Angels* is a particularly realistic film – ritualistic would be a better term. Embedded in its surface is all the jargon that has become automatically

## Movie Maverick: 100 Years of Roger Corman

**Roger Corman: Hollywood's Wild Angel + Roger Corman at the NFT**
Mon 19 Oct 18:30; Wed 4 Nov 20:30
**Machine Gun Kelly**
Mon 19 Oct 20:40; Sat 14 Nov 12:20
**The Masque of the Red Death**
Tue 20 Oct 18:30; Sat 31 Oct 20:50; Fri 27 Nov 18:15
**House of Usher (aka The Fall of the House of Usher)**
Tue 20 Oct 20:45; Sat 14 Nov 14:45 (+ intro by Julie Corman, producer and Roger Corman's wife)
**A Bucket of Blood**
Wed 21 Oct 21:00; Fri 13 Nov 20:50 (+ intro by Mary Corman, Roger Corman's daughter); Sun 22 Nov 12:00
**The Wild Angels**
Thu 22 Oct 18:20; Sun 1 Nov 15:00; Thu 12 Nov 20:30 (+ intro by Catherine Corman, Roger Corman's daughter)
**The Terror**
Thu 22 Oct 20:50; Fri 20 Nov 18:35
**The Little Shop of Horrors**
Sat 24 Oct 20:30; Sun 15 Nov 15:30
**The Pit and the Pendulum**
Sun 25 Oct 15:40; Thu 19 Nov 20:50; Mon 30 Nov 18:20
**The Intruder**
Sun 25 Oct 18:20; Fri 13 Nov 18:10 (+ intro by Julie Corman, producer and Roger Corman's wife); Tue 17 Nov 21:00
**X: The Man with X-Ray Eyes**
Tue 27 Oct 18:30; Mon 23 Nov 21:00
**The St. Valentine's Day Massacre**
Fri 30 Oct 20:50; Thu 19 Nov 18:20
**The Raven**
Sat 31 Oct 16:10; Sun 22 Nov 18:00
**Attack of the Crab Monsters**
Mon 2 Nov 20:55; Sat 21 Nov 18:30
**Roger Corman's Frankenstein Unbound**
Thu 5 Nov 20:45; Sun 29 Nov 18:30
**The Trip: Director's Cut**
Wed 18 Nov 20:55; Thu 26 Nov 18:40

**With thanks to**
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associated with the anti-social motorcyclist since his personification by Brando and his deification by Warhol and Anger: the Nazi insignia, the inarticulate drawl, the bursts of petty violence, the glittering, growling machines, the shapelessly pounding beat music that accompanies each patrol along the streets. In such respects, *Wild Angels* is just what one would anticipate, a reasonably detached study of a collection of bizarre and repellent hooligans intent on justifying to the full the image that conventional society has dreamed up for them. In that their leader ultimately sees the error of his ways, one can even produce the standard 'defence' for Corman's temerity in shocking us with casual rapes and desecrations by saying that of course he is revealing the basic emptiness of the gang's lives, and that no youngsters are going to be tempted into such activities by this harrowing spectacle. True as far as it goes, but Corman fortunately has far more on his mind.

This is instantly established by the opening shot, in which a runaway toddler on a push-bike pedals hell-for-leather for freedom only to find his way blocked by the wheel of Peter Fonda's machine. As his mother sweeps him nervously back into the nest, the duality of the Angels' existence is neatly defined: on the one hand, they are children who need to refute the authority that will always defeat them in the end, while on the other they serve to define that authority by the very fact of their insolent existence. While unable to live within convention, they are equally incapable of surviving without it. And the interesting point here is that none of the Angels looks much under the age of 30 – they give the impression of putting up a desperate, losing battle with age as much as with the subtle decadence of middle-class life.

Not for nothing is Fonda's henchman called 'Loser'; he has a wife, a house, and a job, yet the whole film is concerned with the effect his death has on the gang. They rob him of each of these encumbrances (in reverse order) as the film unfolds, in an unconscious and pathetic attempt to make him truly one of them again; but the Loser stays lost, killed quite literally by their affection for him. Representing the gang's heart, mind and voice, their leader (Fonda) insists on a proper burial for their friend, and as the cacophonous forces of law and order roll up he stands alone in the graveyard shovelling earth on the coffin.

To clarify the significance of this ending a glance back to the Poe films is useful. As a generalisation, they deal with an iconoclast who has lost the most precious thing in his life and seeks, with a blazing insanity, to recreate it; in effect, this refusal to accept the passage of time and the necessary deprivations it inflicts on mind and body comes from the instinctive terror of disfigurement and death – a terror which, however natural, has the additional complication of being agnostic and therefore inadmissible. Vincent Price tended to resolve the conflict by going up in flames, preferably with his beloved's animated corpse around him. The fallen Angel, however, is less melodramatic. His relationship with the Loser having discreetly approached the intensity of a love affair, he found the concept of the Loser's death intolerable and was party to his resurrection (when he is taken from the coffin to celebrate his funeral); but whereas Ligeia showed some animation when wishfully revitalised, the Loser's devotee has remained sane and the Loser has consequently remained very dead.

So *Wild Angels* ends on a note of cold equilibrium; the social outcast has accepted neither the abomination of a respectable life nor the futility of its opposite. He waits among the tombstones for the only certainty, and his homage with clods of earth is at the same time a religious and an anti-religious gesture. It's a glumly existentialist compromise, but at least he hasn't been reduced to ashes. And the Loser has taught him something after all – that it's as possible to live with sorrow as to die of it.

Philip Strick, *Sight and Sound*, Winter 1968-69